EXPERIMENT 2:

Setting up a Zoho Creator Account and Exploring the Platform Architecture and Interface

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Introduction

This report documents a hands-on exploration of Zoho Creator, a low-code application development platform that enables users to design custom business applications through a combination of drag-and-drop tools (Forms, Reports, and Pages) and optional scripting (Deluge) for advanced automation. The walkthrough covers two aspects of the platform: the account-level administration console, which governs users, security, deployment, and monitoring across all applications; and the application builder itself, where an individual app's forms, fields, and submission logic are configured. The screenshots below are presented in the order they were captured, each accompanied by a description of what the screen shows and how it fits into Creator's overall architecture.

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Part A: Account Dashboard and Platform Administration

Landing on the Zoho Creator Home Dashboard

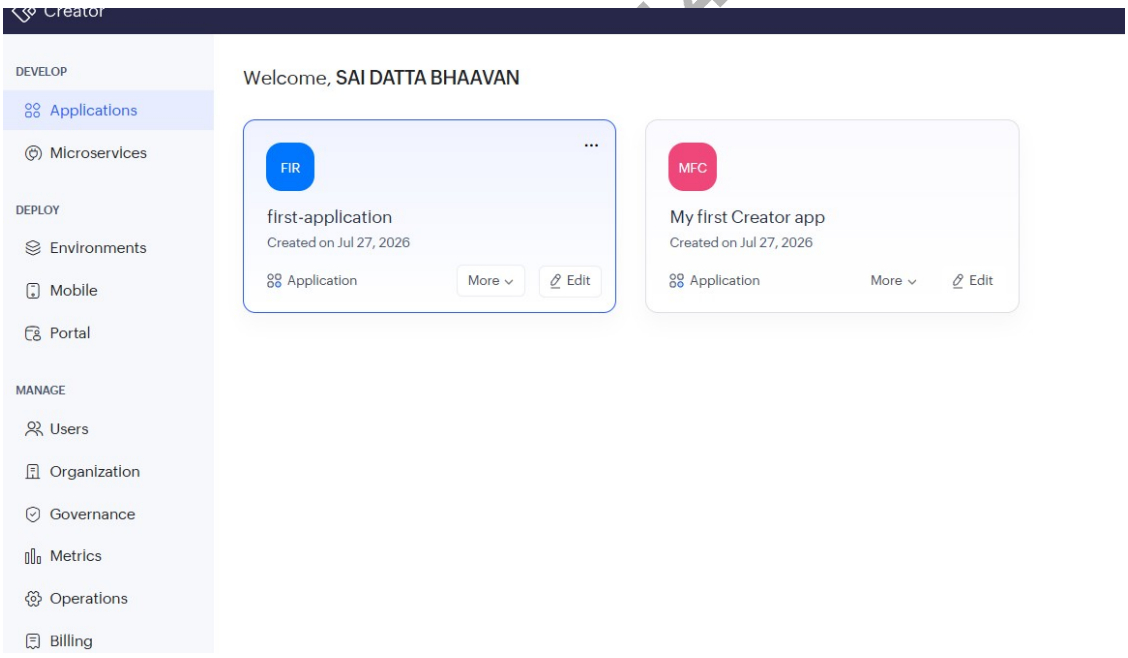


Figure 1: Zoho Creator home dashboard

After signing in, the user lands on the Creator home dashboard, which lists all applications tied to the account — in this case, first-application and My first Creator app, both created via the "Create Application" flow. The dashboard consolidates application management and creation into a single, uncluttered view, reflecting Creator's low-code philosophy of minimizing setup friction.

Microservices

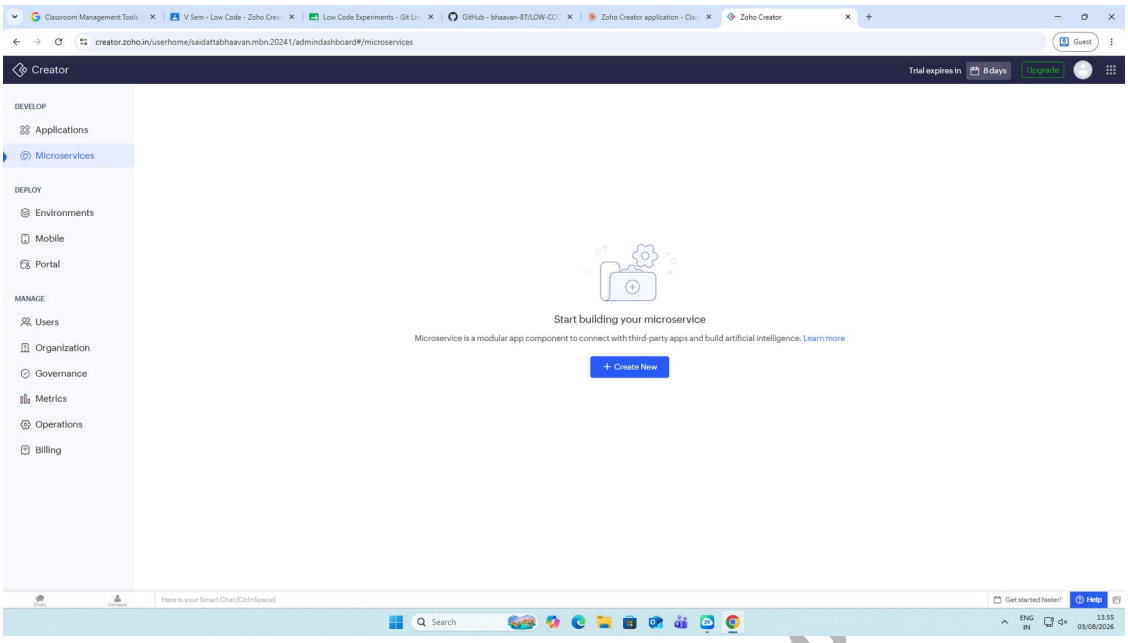


Figure 2: Microservices section (unused)

The Microservices section allows a modular app component to be built for connecting with third-party services and AI features. In this account it is currently unused, shown by the "Start building your microservice" prompt, but it represents the layer of the architecture responsible for integrations and extensibility beyond the core app.

Environments

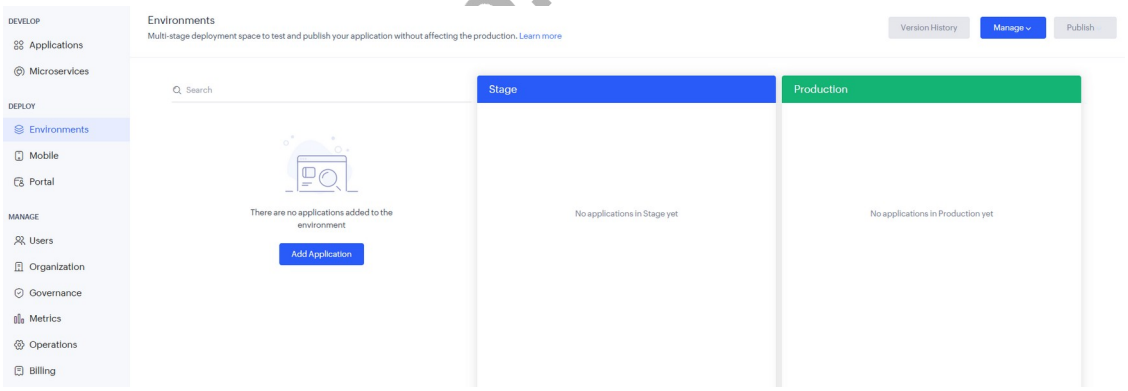


Figure 3: Stage and Production environments

The Environments screen provides a multi-stage deployment space — separate Stage and Production columns — allowing an application to be tested before it is published live. No applications have been added to either environment yet, but this view illustrates Creator's built-in deployment lifecycle management, letting changes be validated without affecting a live production app.

Portal

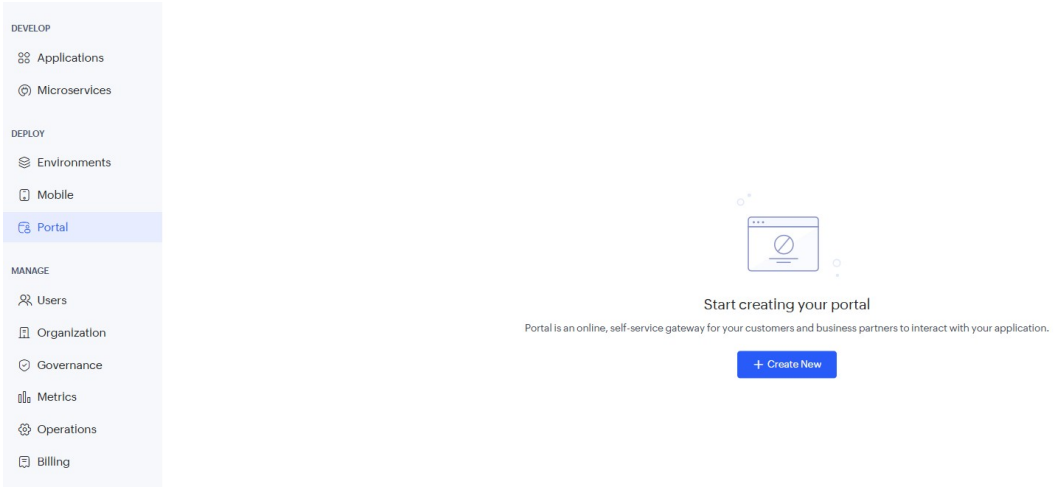


Figure 4: Portal (unconfigured)

Portal is an online, self-service gateway that lets external customers or business partners interact directly with a published application. It is currently unconfigured, but its presence in the Deploy section shows that Creator supports external-facing access alongside internal-only apps.

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Users

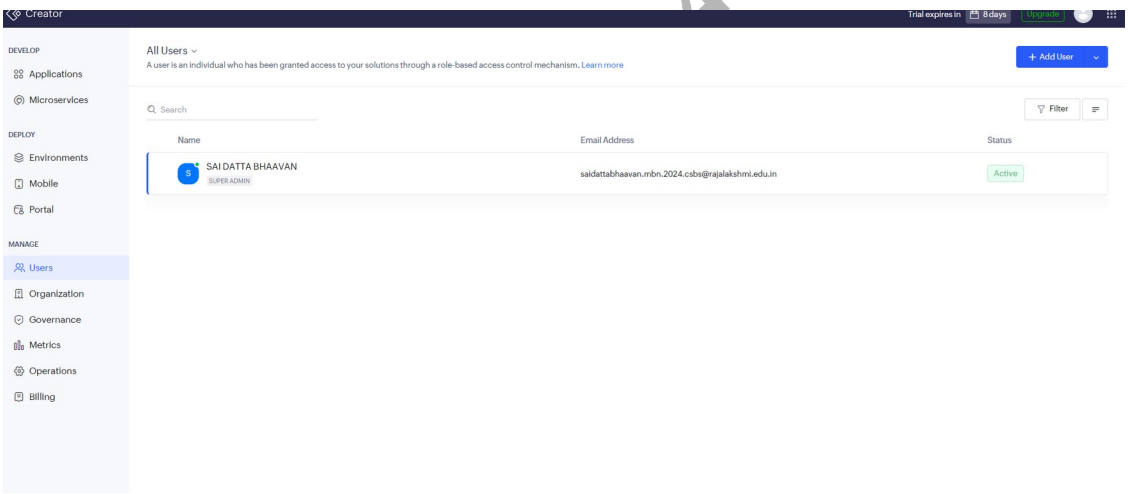


Figure 5: Users and role-based access

The Users screen lists everyone with access to the account under a role-based access control model — here showing a single Super Admin. This is the account-level counterpart to the in-app permissions discussed later, and demonstrates how Creator separates "who can manage the account" from "who can use a specific app."

Organization

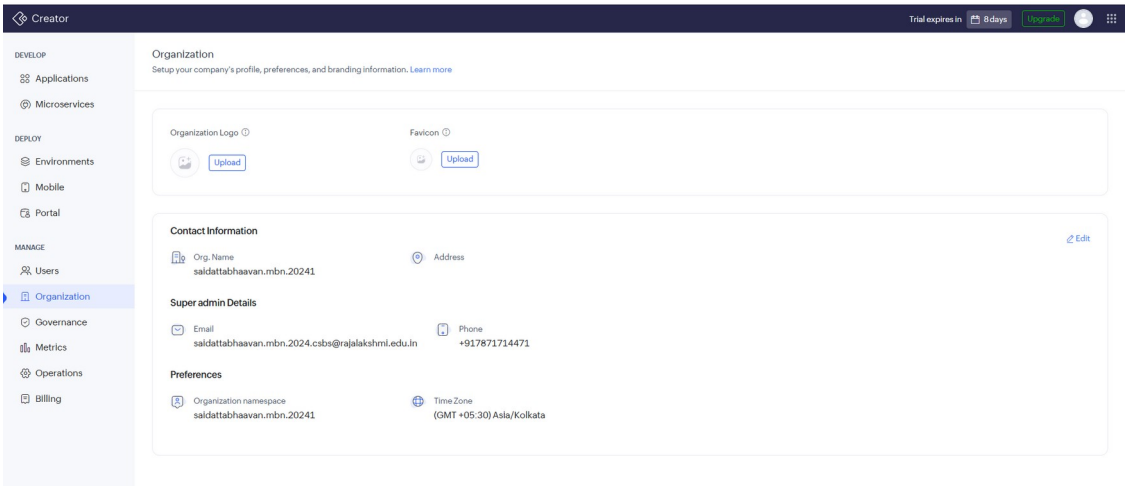


Figure 6: Organization profile settings

The Organization page holds company-level profile and branding information — organization name, super admin contact details, namespace, and time zone. This centralizes account identity settings that apply across every application built under the account.

Governance

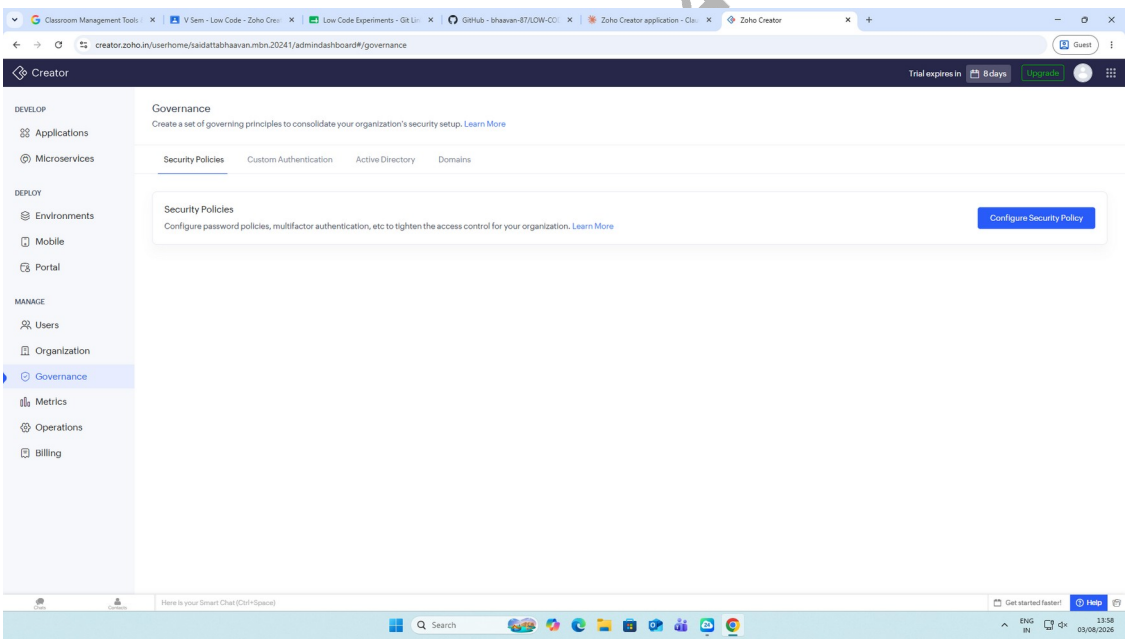


Figure 7: Governance and security policies

Governance consolidates the organization's security setup, including Security Policies (password rules, multi-factor authentication), Custom Authentication, Active Directory integration, and Domains. This is the cross-cutting security layer that applies uniformly across all apps and users in the account.

Metrics

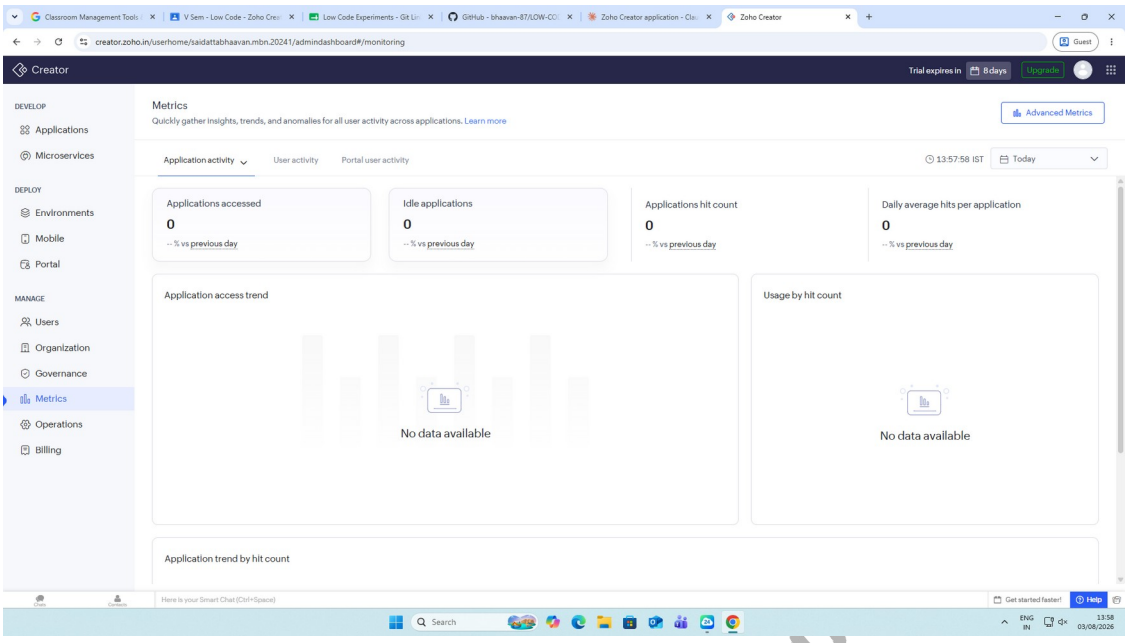


Figure 8: Metrics and usage dashboard

The Metrics dashboard gives account owners visibility into application usage — accessed applications, idle applications, hit counts, and access trends — supporting the Monitoring & Administration layer of the platform architecture.

Operations

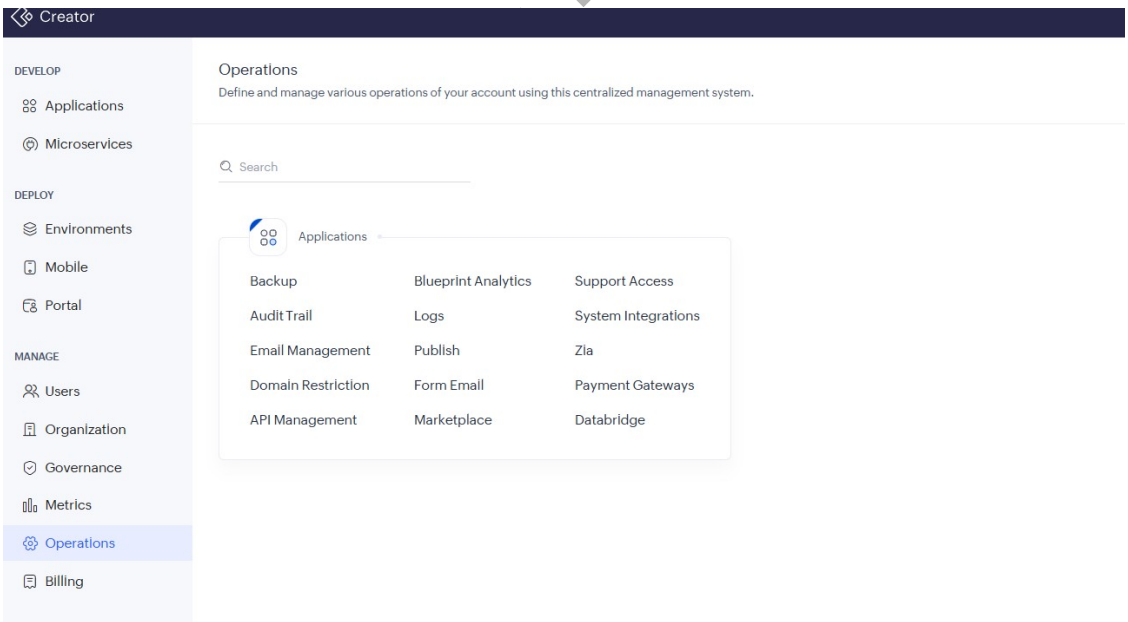


Figure 9: Operations control center

Operations centralizes a wide set of account-wide controls: Backup, Audit Trail, Email Management, Domain Restriction, API Management, Blueprint Analytics, Logs, Publish, Form Email, Marketplace, Support Access, System Integrations, Zia (AI), Payment Gateways, and Databridge. This single screen reflects how much of Creator's underlying platform capability is exposed through configuration rather than code.

Part B: Building Inside an Application

The Application Builder Workspace

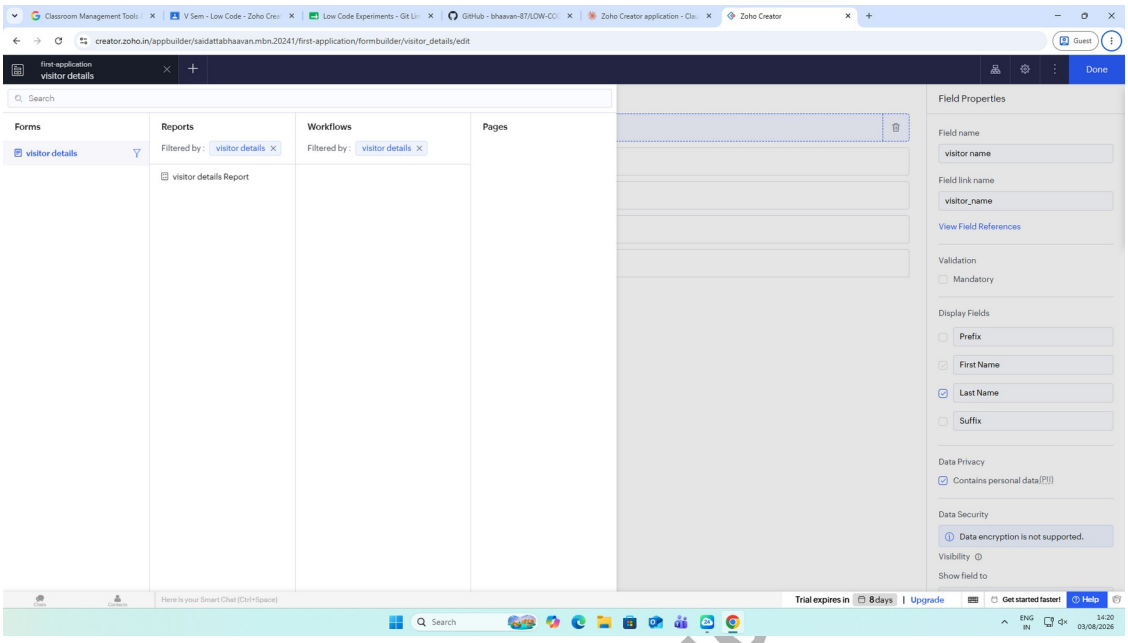


Figure 10: Builder workspace — Forms, Reports, Workflows, Pages

Opening first-application via Edit leads into its dedicated builder workspace. The interface is organized into four columns — Forms, Reports, Workflows, and Pages — reflecting Creator's core idea that an application is essentially a linked collection of a data-capture form, the reports built from it, the automation logic attached to it, and the pages that present it. Here, a "visitor details" form is shown with an auto-generated "visitor details Report," while the Workflows and Pages columns remain empty, not yet configured.

Form Builder and Field Palette

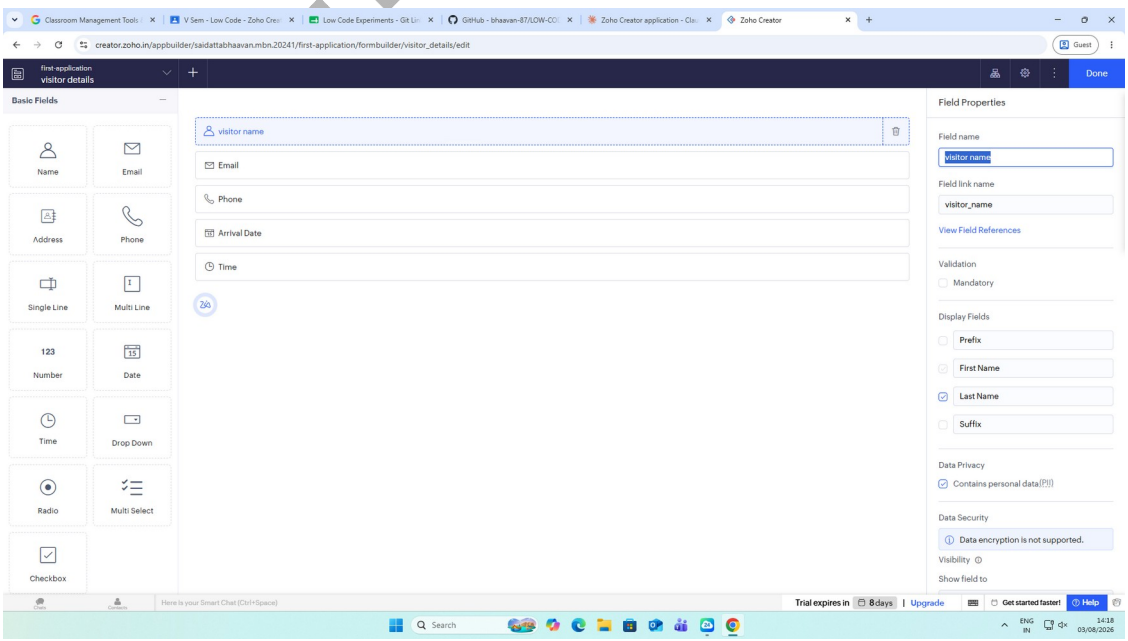


Figure 11: Form Builder with field palette

The Form Builder shows the "visitor details" form under construction, with fields for visitor name, Email, Phone, Arrival Date, and Time already placed on the canvas. Alongside it, a palette of Basic Fields (Name, Email, Address, Phone, Single Line, Multi Line, Number, Date, Time, Drop Down, Radio, Multi Select, Checkbox) allows new fields to be dragged directly onto the form. This drag-and-drop approach abstracts database schema design away from the end user entirely.

Configuring Field Properties

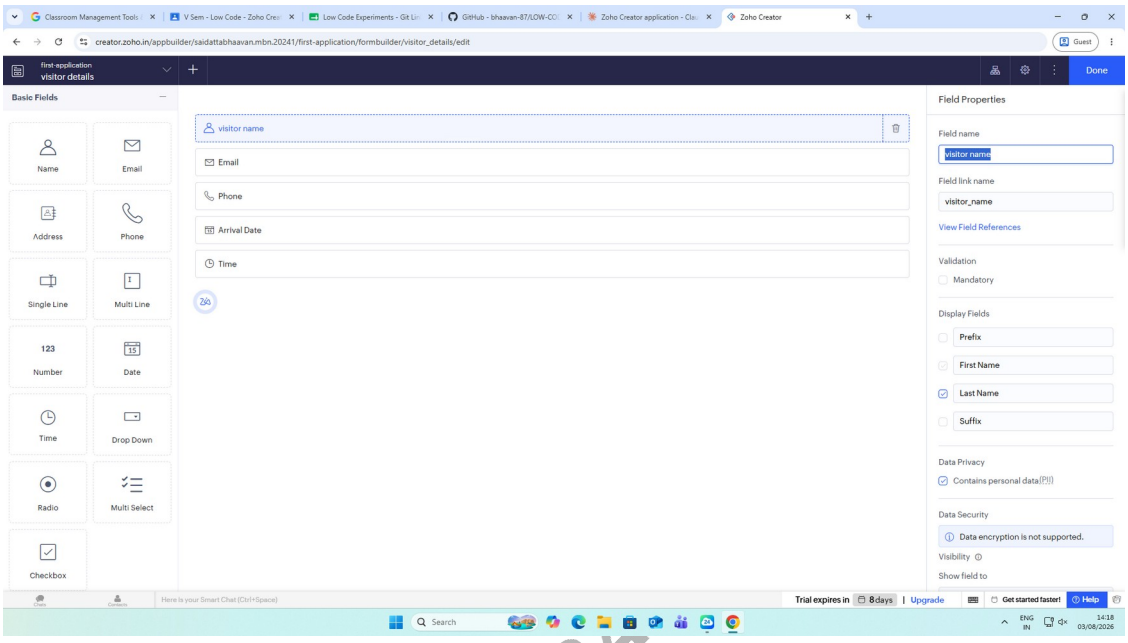


Figure 12: Field Properties panel — visitor name field

Selecting the "visitor name" field opens its Field Properties panel, where its field name and field link name can be set, along with validation (Mandatory), display sub-fields (Prefix, First Name, Last Name, Suffix), and Data Privacy settings — including a "Contains personal data (PII)" flag. This shows Creator's support for meaningful data governance at the individual field level, not just the form as a whole.

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Configuring Form Submission Behavior

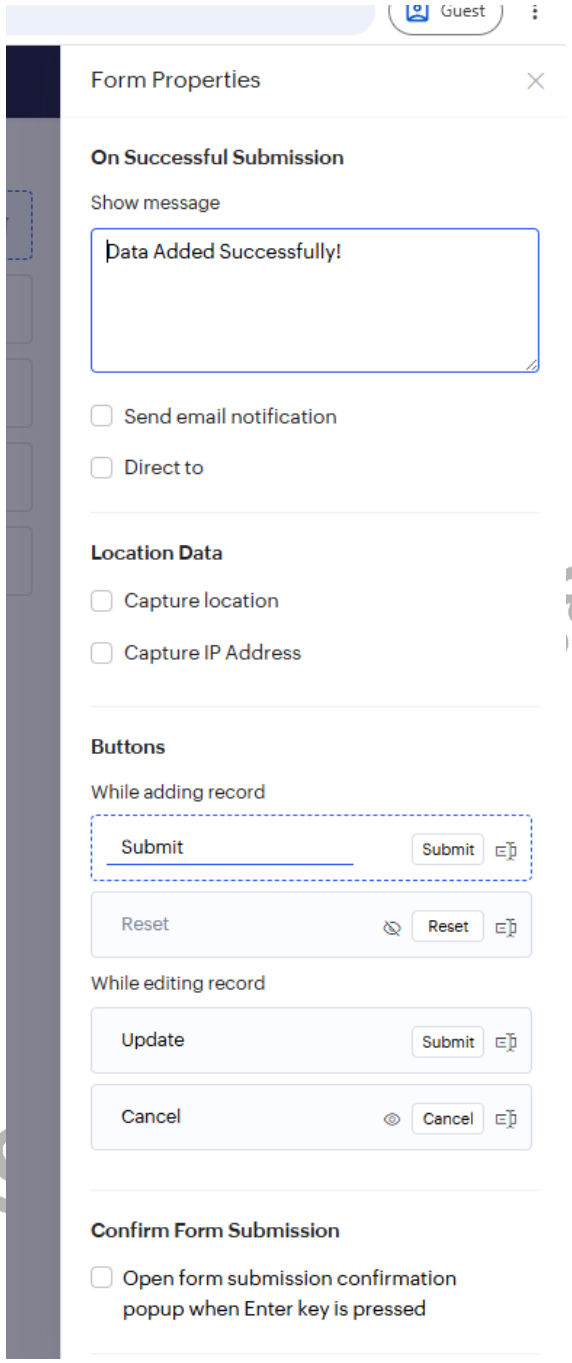


Figure 13: Form submission and button configuration

The Form Properties panel controls what happens after a record is submitted: a custom success message ("Data Added Successfully!"), optional email notifications, optional location/IP capture, and customizable Submit, Reset, Update, and Cancel buttons for both the add and edit states. This demonstrates how Creator lets non-developers define post-submission logic purely through configuration.

Conclusion

This walkthrough covered two layers of Zoho Creator's architecture: the account-level administration console — Users, Organization, Governance, Metrics, Operations, Environments, and Portal — which governs access, security, deployment, and monitoring across the whole account; and the application

builder itself, where a single app's Forms, field-level validation and privacy rules, and submission behavior are configured through visual tools rather than code. Together, these layers illustrate Creator's overall design: centralized governance and monitoring at the account level, paired with a flexible, drag-and-drop builder at the application level, allowing both administrators and citizen developers to work within the same platform at the level suited to their role.

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